EVERYDAY SKILL

AI Prompt Cheat Sheets

Ask better questions. Get more useful answers.

A plain-English toolkit for getting useful work out of an AI assistant, without memorizing magic words.

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PLAIN ENGLISH ON PURPOSE

Print it. Write on it.
Make it yours.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 01

The five parts of a clear prompt

A prompt is just a request with enough context to be useful. You do not need secret phrases. You need to tell the AI what you are trying to do, what it should know, and what a good answer looks like.

The five slots

01 **Goal:** Name the outcome. “Help me prepare for a meeting” is clearer than “work stuff.”

02 **Context:** Add the who, what, and why. A little real detail beats a long vague story.

03 **Materials:** Paste the notes or name the source you want it to use — and tell it not to add outside facts.

04 **Format:** Ask for a table, five bullets, a 150-word draft, a checklist, or a step-by-step plan.

05 **Boundaries:** Say what to avoid, what not to invent, and what to do when it is unsure.

PROMPT RECIPE — THE ALL-PURPOSE STARTER

```
Help me [goal].
Here’s what’s going on: [context].
Use this material: [paste notes or name your source].
Give me: [format and length].
Keep it [tone]. Don’t [boundary].
If anything important is missing, ask me up to three questions before you start.
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PROMPT RECIPE — WEAK: TOO LITTLE TO WORK WITH

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Write about meal planning.
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PROMPT RECIPE — STRONGER: ENOUGH TO HELP

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I need five weeknight dinners for two people who eat
vegetarian.
We’re okay with leftovers, but not mushrooms, and we have
about
25 minutes to cook. Give me a table of meals, then a
shopping list
grouped by grocery section. Ask before assuming we own
special tools.
```

TRY THIS

One line that improves most prompts

“Ask me up to three questions if anything important is missing.” It brings back the missing detail without turning the task into a twenty-message interrogation. Not every prompt needs all five slots — but the brackets are where the usefulness lives.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 01

Everyday prompts that earn their keep

These are the ones worth taping to the fridge. Swap the bracketed details for your real situation, then delete anything that does not fit.

PROMPT RECIPE — EXPLAIN IT PLAINLY

Explain [topic] in plain English for someone who [context]. Use one everyday analogy, then walk me through it in five short steps. Put any term that needs defining in bold. Keep it under 250 words.

PROMPT RECIPE — TURN A MESS INTO A SUMMARY

Turn the notes below into (1) a five-bullet summary, (2) a separate “Decisions” list, and (3) a “Next actions” list with an owner for each. Do not add facts that aren’t in the notes.

Notes: [paste]

PROMPT RECIPE — FIND THE FIRST STEP

I feel stuck with [task] because [why]. Ask me up to three questions, then give me a 20-minute first step, a one-hour version, and a low-energy version. Do not give me a twelve-step plan.

PROMPT RECIPE — COMPARE WITHOUT THE HYPE

Help me choose between [A], [B], and [C]. My priorities are [priority one] and [priority two]. My constraints are [time, budget, energy]. Make a simple comparison table, name the trade-offs, and recommend the option that fits my priorities — not the one that sounds most impressive.

PROMPT RECIPE — REHEARSE A HARD CONVERSATION

Role-play a conversation where I need to [say no / ask for help / set a boundary] with [person and relationship]. Be realistic, not a pushover. Start with the other person’s likely reaction. After each of my replies, respond as they might, then give me one short coaching note. Stay in the scene until I type END.

GOOD TO KNOW

A good prompt is a conversation starter

You are allowed — encouraged, even — to say “That’s not it. Try again, but shorter and less cheerful.” The first answer is a draft of the request, not a verdict on your idea.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 01

Turn the AI into a tutor

A useful tutor does not simply talk at you. It finds out what you know, makes you produce something, and points to the next small gap. These prompts set that up.

PROMPT RECIPE — TUTOR, DON'T TELL

Be my tutor for [topic]. Don't explain everything at once. Ask me one question at a time, starting with something I already know. Wait for my answer. If I'm wrong, give me a hint before the explanation. After five questions, give me a one-page recap.

PROMPT RECIPE — QUIZ ME PROPERLY

Make a ten-question quiz on [topic] for someone at [level]. Mix recall, application, and one tricky question. Ask one question at a time and wait. Don't show the answers until I'm done. Then explain the ones I missed.

PROMPT RECIPE — GRADE MY EXPLANATION

I'll explain [concept] in my own words. Grade it for accuracy and clarity on a 1–5 scale. Name one thing I got right, one gap, and one small next question I should be able to answer. Don't rewrite it for me yet.

My explanation: [paste]

Use a source, not just a summary

Paste your course notes, cite the book, or name the article. Then add: "If the source doesn't cover something, say so instead of filling the gap." AI can explain a topic beautifully and still sand off the one detail that matters. Your source keeps the conversation grounded.

TRY THIS

The test of a good study session

Could you now explain the idea without the chat window open? If not, ask for another round of questions — not another summary. Retrieval beats rereading.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 01

Prompts for work and writing

These are drafts, not decisions. Read them aloud, check every date and promise, and keep the parts that sound like a person you would trust.

PROMPT RECIPE — THE EMAIL THAT GETS TO THE POINT

Rewrite the draft email below for clarity and warmth. Keep it under [number] words, preserve every commitment and date, and give me a subject line. Don’t make it stiff or add claims I didn’t make.

Draft: [paste]

PROMPT RECIPE — SHORTEN WITHOUT FLATTENING

Cut this to [length] while keeping the facts, the specific examples, and my voice. Put any phrase you removed in a list below the edit so I can decide what to restore.

Text: [paste]

PROMPT RECIPE — NOTES INTO ACTIONS

Turn these meeting notes into: (1) decisions, (2) open questions, (3) action items with an owner and due date if stated, and (4) anything I should verify. Do not assign an owner or deadline that isn’t in the notes.

Notes: [paste]

PROMPT RECIPE — A HARD MESSAGE, HANDLED WITH CARE

Help me write a [number]-sentence message to [person or role] about [issue]. State the situation plainly, avoid blame, and include a specific next step. Give me two versions: direct and gentle. Don’t invent an apology or a promise.

Facts: [paste]

PROMPT RECIPE — MAKE A PROCESS REPEATABLE

Turn this process into a one-page checklist a new person could follow: [describe or paste the steps]. Number every step, call out tools or warnings, and flag anything I left ambiguous instead of guessing.

WATCH OUT

Keep the judgment in the room

Do not paste confidential workplace information into an unapproved tool. If the work involves health, legal, HR, money, or other people’s private data, check your employer’s policy first. You are still the author of anything you send.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 01

Prompts for authors and small shops

AI can help you see your own work from a reader's angle. It should not invent credentials, write fake reviews, or promise results you cannot prove. Use it to clarify, not to impersonate.

PROMPT RECIPE — READER-FIRST OUTLINE

I'm writing a [type of book or guide] for [reader] who is [situation]. They want [outcome], but they're worried about [fear]. Suggest three possible structures. For each: the promise, the chapter arc, and a strong first chapter. Ask me three questions before you commit to an outline. Avoid generic advice.

PROMPT RECIPE — STRESS-TEST THE BLURB

Here is my book description: [paste]. Tell me what a tired reader understands in ten seconds, what's vague, and what sounds like every other book in this category. Then give me two tightened versions: warm and direct. Don't invent endorsements, credentials, or sales numbers.

PROMPT RECIPE — EXPLORE TITLES HONESTLY

Brainstorm fifteen titles for [project] about [core idea] for [reader]. Use these tones: [warm, practical, bold]. Flag accidental clichés and anything that overpromises. Then pick three and explain the trade-off in one line each — don't just tell me what I want to hear.

PROMPT RECIPE — A LISTING THAT SAYS WHAT IT IS

Turn these product details into a clear listing for [platform]: [details]. Lead with the outcome for the buyer, include what's inside, who it's for, and a plain "what it isn't" line. Keep my voice. Don't invent reviews, guarantees, or results.

PROMPT RECIPE — TURN REAL QUESTIONS INTO USEFUL CONTENT

Here are real questions customers ask me: [paste]. Group them by theme and suggest eight short content pieces that answer them plainly. For each, give a hook, the one useful idea, and a soft next step. No fake urgency and no engagement bait.

GOOD TO KNOW

Your byline comes with your responsibility

AI can make a weak promise sound polished. You are still the one accountable for accuracy, copyright, claims, and tone. Reject anything that makes your reader feel tricked into buying.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 01

Ask for evidence, not applause

AI is very good at sounding confident. A useful assistant can be right and wrong in the same paragraph. These prompts make it show its work, name uncertainty, and separate facts from guesses.

PROMPT RECIPE — SOURCE-GROUNDED BRIEF

Using only the source below, make a one-page brief: the main claim, three supporting facts, one contradiction or tension, and what's missing. Quote short phrases for each fact. If the source doesn't answer something, write "not stated."

Source: [paste]

PROMPT RECIPE — STEELMAN THE OTHER SIDE

I currently believe [position] about [issue]. Steelman the best case against it, then the best case for it. Label facts versus interpretations. Finish by naming the one piece of evidence that would most change the picture.

PROMPT RECIPE — CHECK THIS CLAIM

Here is a claim I want to check: [claim]. Break it into separate factual claims. For each, tell me: (a) what would count as evidence, (b) how I could verify it with an official or primary source, (c) your confidence, and (d) what you might be missing. Do not invent citations or links.

PROMPT RECIPE — UNCERTAINTY FIRST

Before answering [question], list what you don't know, what is likely to change, and what could make your answer wrong. Then answer, and keep those uncertainties visible in a note at the end.

PROMPT RECIPE — A DECISION MATRIX

Help me compare [options]. Ask for my criteria and their weights before scoring if I haven't given them. Then make a simple table with a confidence note for each score. Separate facts from judgment. Finish with a recommendation and one question I should ask a human expert.

WATCH OUT

A citation is not proof

If an AI gives you links, open them and read them. If it gives you a fact that matters, confirm it with a primary or official source — or with a person who actually knows. A plausible URL can still be wrong, dead, or about something else entirely.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 01

When the answer misses

You do not have to start over. Name what went wrong, keep what worked, and ask for a specific change. Most weak answers improve with one honest follow-up.

WHAT WENT WRONG	WHAT TO SAY NEXT
Too vague or generic	“Give me three specific versions, each with a concrete example and a different trade-off.”
Too long or padded	“Cut this by half without losing facts. Put anything you removed in a list below.”
Not in my voice	“List the five phrases that sound least like me, propose replacements, then rewrite only those sections.”
Invented details	“Mark every factual claim as verified, inferred, or unknown. Rewrite using only verified claims.”
Ignored a limit	“Restate the task and my constraints in one sentence. Tell me which constraint you missed.”
Too agreeable	“Argue against my idea for one paragraph. Make the strongest honest case, not a straw man.”

PROMPT RECIPE — THE CLEAN RESTART

Let’s restart this cleanly.
What I want: [goal].
What I actually need: [specific output].
The context you were missing: [details].
Keep: [what worked].
Avoid: [what didn’t].
Before answering, summarize the task in one sentence and ask me up to two questions.

Build one you can reuse

Open a note called “My prompts.” Save the version you actually used, not a perfect version you never tried. Add one line about what you would change next time.

TRY THIS

A prompt is not a performance

Short and clear beats long and clever. If you would feel strange reading the prompt out loud to a colleague, make it simpler.

ONE LAST THING · 01

Use one thing. Then keep it.

Pick one prompt from this guide, use it on a real task today, and edit it until the wording sounds like you.

MY NEXT SMALL STEP

THE RULE FOR THIS HALF OF THE PACK

Use AI like a useful first draft — not a final authority. Keep your judgment, check the facts, and protect private information.

More AI printables

- 02 Beginner AI Glossary
- 03 AI Privacy Checklist
- 04 AI for Job Search
- 05 AI for Budgeting
- 06 The 7-Day AI Learning Challenge

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Keep the useful part. Leave the rest.